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Attribution-Reading Guide

GA4's attribution models, what they cannot see, and the checks to run before you move a single rupee on an attribution report. Read it as a probability, not a verdict.

GA4's three attribution models

Model	How it splits credit	Good for	Watch out for
Data-driven (default)	Compares converting and non-converting paths to estimate how much each touchpoint changed the odds	A balanced view in accounts with plenty of conversions	It is an estimate, and it only credits touchpoints GA4 recorded
Paid and organic last click	All credit to the last channel clicked before converting; direct visits ignored	Seeing which channels close	Early research and awareness get no credit
Google paid channels last click	All credit to the last Google Ads click, if there was one	Reading Google Ads in isolation	Everything outside Google Ads disappears

First click, linear, time decay, and position-based models were removed from GA4 in November 2023. Source: Google Analytics Help, "Get started with attribution." Also check your lookback window in GA4's attribution settings: journeys that began before it are cut short.

What no GA4 model can see

- TV, hoardings, and other offline media
- Word of mouth and referrals
- Sales visits and dealer recommendations
- Links shared without tags, on WhatsApp or in apps
- Sales that close by phone or in person, unless imported

Credit for all of this goes to whichever tracked touch came last.

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In one real account, direct traffic reached four times organic search in a single month: 2,299 users against 556. Direct means GA4 could not tell where visitors came from. The likely cause was untagged traffic, not a surge in people typing the address.

Electric-vehicle information website, June 2026, anonymised.

Five habits for reading GA4 attribution

1. **Compare the models before you trust one.** Use the model comparison report. Agreement means more confidence. Disagreement shows you the uncertainty.
2. **Read the conversion paths.** The paths report shows the sequence of channels before a conversion: the closest GA4 gets to the whole match.
3. **Tag every link you control.** UTM parameters on emails, WhatsApp messages, QR codes, and partner links keep traffic out of the direct bucket.
4. **Bring offline outcomes in.** Import closed sales from your CRM, or compare them monthly with what GA4 claims. Ask new customers how they heard about you.
5. **Test the big bets.** Change spend in one region or period, hold another steady, and compare total sales.

What the report says, and what it may mean

GA4 says	It may mean	Check this
Direct traffic spiked	Untagged links or campaigns	Recent WhatsApp shares, emails, press mentions
Paid search wins most conversions	Branded searches from people who already knew you	Split brand and non-brand campaigns
Organic gets little credit	Research visits early in the journey	Conversion paths report
Social shows almost no conversions	Influence without the final click	Branded search trend, customer surveys
One channel's conversions doubled	A tracking or settings change	Change history and key event settings

Before you move budget on an attribution report

- [ ] I know which model produced this number, and I have said so in the report.
- [ ] I have compared data-driven with last click for the same period.
- [ ] I have checked total leads and sales, not just credited conversions.
- [ ] I have checked for tagging gaps: no unexplained spike in direct or unassigned traffic.
- [ ] I have compared GA4's claims with offline or CRM sales for the same month.
- [ ] For any large cut, I have a test planned: one region or period changed, one held steady.
- [ ] I will move budget in steps, not all at once, and review after each step.

Presenting attribution to leadership

- **Say which model** is behind every attribution number.
- **Show agreement or disagreement** between models.
- **Name what is missing,** such as offline media or phone sales.
- **Pair it with totals,** so a shift in credit is not mistaken for a change in results.

Write it like this

> **Instead of:** "Paid search drove 62% of conversions."
>
> **Try:** "GA4 credits paid search with most conversions. Last click and data-driven agree, so we are fairly confident. Offline sales are not included."

Illustrative example.

> THE DECISION RULE
>
> Never cut a channel on attribution alone. If GA4 says a channel contributes little, test it: reduce it in one region or period and watch total sales, not credited conversions. If sales hold, the model was right. If they drop, the model was blind.

Is your attribution report telling the whole story?

Our measurement audit checks your GA4 tagging, key events, and attribution setup, and shows you where the report is guessing.

→ **Talk to us about a measurement audit**